

Nikola Bartunkova beats Aryna Sabalenka at China Open

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Nikola Bartunkova beat world number two Aryna Sabalenka at the China Open. A report published on 4 October 2026 described the win as a surprise. Bartunkova, a Czech player ranked 34th in the world, won 6-4, 6-3. She will play Austria's Sinja Kraus next.

Bartunkova said she focused on herself and tried to stay calm. She called Sabalenka a **legend** and said she was very happy to win. The report described this as a season in which Bartunkova was making big progress.

A day earlier, top **seed** Elena Rybakina lost to Armenia's Alina Charaeva, ranked 118th. Rybakina had beaten Sabalenka in last month's US Open final. She then took Sabalenka's place as world number one.

Seeds are players given leading places in a tournament's draw because of their **rankings**. For the first time since 2015, both of the China Open's top two **seeds** failed to reach the **round of 16**.

Sabalenka had five chances to win a game when Bartunkova was serving. These chances are called **break points**. She did not win any of them. She has now lost six matches in a row in which she lost the first set.

Sabalenka's latest titles came in March. She won Indian Wells and then the Miami Open. Winning both events is called the "**Sunshine Double**".

Word Treasure

ranking -- A player's position compared with other players.

seed -- A player given a leading place in a tournament's draw because of their ranking.

break point -- A chance to win a game when the other player is serving.

round of 16 -- The stage of a tournament with 16 players remaining.

legend -- Someone admired for their great achievements.

Sunshine Double -- Winning both Indian Wells and the Miami Open.

Background you need

Seeds receive leading places in a tournament's draw because of their rankings.

A break point is a chance to win a game when the other player is serving.

Winning Indian Wells and the Miami Open is called the "Sunshine Double".

Break it down

The opening gives Bartunkova's surprise result, ranking, match score and next opponent.

The next paragraph shares Bartunkova's comments about staying calm and winning.

The article then explains Rybakina's defeat and the top two seeds missing the round of 16.

The ending describes Sabalenka's missed chances, losing run after dropping the first set and latest titles.

Why it matters

Bartunkova beat a player ranked much higher than her. The result also meant that both of the China Open's top two seeds missed the round of 16 for the first time since 2015.

Test what you remember

1. Who did Nikola Bartunkova beat at the China Open?

- ☐ (A) Alina Charaeva
- ☐ (B) Sinja Kraus
- ☐ (C) Elena Rybakina
- ☐ (D) Aryna Sabalenka

2. What was the score of Bartunkova's win?

- ☐ (A) 6-3, 6-4
- ☐ (B) 6-4, 6-3
- ☐ (C) 6-3, 6-3
- ☐ (D) 6-4, 6-4

3. What did Bartunkova say she tried to do during the match?

- ☐ (A) Focus on herself and stay calm
- ☐ (B) Avoid thinking about her own game
- ☐ (C) Watch Sinja Kraus play
- ☐ (D) Think about the Miami Open

4. Who will Bartunkova play next?

- ☐ (A) Elena Rybakina
- ☐ (B) Austria's Sinja Kraus
- ☐ (C) Aryna Sabalenka again
- ☐ (D) Armenia's Alina Charaeva

5. How many break points did Sabalenka win against Bartunkova?

- ☐ (A) Three
- ☐ (B) None
- ☐ (C) All five
- ☐ (D) One

6. What does winning the "Sunshine Double" mean?

- ☐ (A) Beating both top seeds at the China Open
- ☐ (B) Reaching the round of 16 twice
- ☐ (C) Winning Indian Wells and the Miami Open
- ☐ (D) Winning the first two sets of a match

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: A 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Nikola Bartunkova:** She said she focused on herself, tried to stay calm and felt very happy to win. She called Sabalenka a legend.
2. **The report:** It described the win as a surprise and Bartunkova's season as one of big progress.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):